emerged as the most influential religious leader in Tibet. Kunga Gyaltsen had a strong India connection, having studied Sanskrit under a renowned Kashmiri teacher, Sakyasribhadra. It is from this point onwards that he became known as the Sakya Pandita and predecessors in his lineage at the Sakya monastery were retrospectively accorded the title of Pandita. Kunga Gyaltsen submitted to Mongol overlordship on behalf of the Tibetan principalities. During the rule of Kublai Khan, who established the Yuan dynasty (see Chapter 9), the Sakya Pandita was appointed as the Imperial Preceptor and made the leader of all Buddhists in the Mongol realms. His nephew, Drogon Chogyal Phagpa, became the administrator of Tibet but under the overall administrative and military authority of the Mongol emperor.

There is no doubt that at this time Tibet was part of the Yuan empire, but with the establishment of the emperor–preceptor or 'patron–priest' relationship, it was somewhat different from the usual Chinese-style 'tributary' relationship. Nevertheless, the current Chinese state claims that Tibet became an integral part of China since the Yuan dynasty. A note issued by the Chinese embassy in India on 15 April 2015 asserts this claim in definitive terms:

> In plain terms, Tibet has been a part of China since ancient times. The thousand-year Tibetan-Han relationship covers two stages: one in the Tang dynasty, Tibetan and Han people formed an alliance; since the Yuan dynasty they have belonged to the same country. [3]

But during the Yuan dynasty in China, Tibet's relationship was with the Mongols and not with the Han. Tibet was a part of the Mongol empire, as were China, Korea and Vietnam. When the Mongol empire ended, Tibet shed the Mongol yoke and became an independent kingdom under King Changchub Gyaltsen (1350–1364 CE) of the Phagmodru dynasty, who overthrew the hegemony of the Sakya Pandita. This dynasty ruled Tibet for almost hundred years when it was replaced by another Tibetan dynasty under the Rimpung of Tsang, central Tibet, in 1481. The kings of Tsang would rule up until 1642, when the fifth Dalai Lama, 'the Great Fifth', established the temporal and religious rule of the Dalai Lamas over the country.